



Bond this way: “Our coach Tan (Kim Her) told us to go out, roam together, have a meal together and share a room together. These small things changed us. And we got to know more about each other as we travelled together,” says Satwik. GETTYIMAGES

T-shirts. There are many other ways to celebrate. I’ve never met her in person, but it was pretty funny to have that comment on my post.

You guys have your own individual style. How did you get together as a group?

Satwik: We had coach Tan (Kim Her) who said we must be together. He told us to go out, roam together, have a meal together and share a room together. These small things changed us. And we got to know more about each other as we travelled together. From my side I opened up a little more when I started talking to him. When we started getting along, it helped us on the court as well. Initially I was a very Telugu person. I watched only Telugu

movies, hung out only with other Telugu people. Ate almost only South Indian food. Shetty *bhai* is almost the opposite. He doesn’t eat Indian food. He likes eating Korean or Japanese food. So, we learned to compromise. For one meal we would eat Indian food and for the next, we might go to his favourite kind of restaurant. It’s like a marriage. We fight but sort it out. It’s not like we have big fights but if we have small disagreements; we will sort it out there itself. It’s become much better these days. We have now been together for nearly 7-8 years. We trust each other. We are like brothers now.

Chirag: Satwik’s adapted a lot. He’s started trying different cuisines. Earlier it was just Indian. Now he has Thai. Chinese of course. Anything with rice is good for him.

When you communicate, you seem like you have some signs to signal each other. What are they?

Satwik: That’s to show where I’m going to serve. I’ll usually make either 1-2 or 3. 1 means I’m hitting the T-joint. 3 is in the corner. Thumbs up

means I’m going to flick it back. It’s been there for a very long time. There are other things that I’ll communicate through speaking. For example, I might want to say that I’m going to be covering one side. So, I’ll say ‘Shetty *bhai main aage bhagunga*’. If our opponents aren’t Indian, they won’t understand.

Initially it was tough even for me to say these things (to Chirag) because I only spoke Telugu. Then [when I started playing with Chirag] this became a bit of a struggle because I would think how I should say this in Hindi. And by the time I realised how to say what I wanted; the rally would be over. When I got better then it became much easier.

You will have a difference in opinions. How do you sort it out, especially during a match?

Satwik: We never got that situation yet. If we are not on the same page, we have a third person — the coach sitting behind us — to act as a tiebreaker. We follow his strategy. We are on the same page when we both are on the same strategy. Now though, I know 100 per cent Shetty *bhai kidhar marega*. (where Chirag will hit). We stick to our strong points, which is to attack.

Shetty *bhai ka kaam hai ki mujhe opening dena hai* (Chirag’s role is to give me openings). My job is to finish it. The next shuttle Chirag will catch. So that’s plan A for us. But if that is not working and we become confused, then Mathias (Boe) will be back sitting, and he will tell us to do this or that.

When you started, doubles wasn’t a big thing in India. Why did you choose to be a doubles player then?

Chirag: At that time, when we started out, there were hardly a lot of doubles players, and you didn’t really get that amount of importance and respect in India. Firstly, badminton isn’t that popular a sport in India compared to cricket. So, if you are a badminton player already, your popularity is low. If you are a doubles player, then compared to singles players your popularity is even lower.